

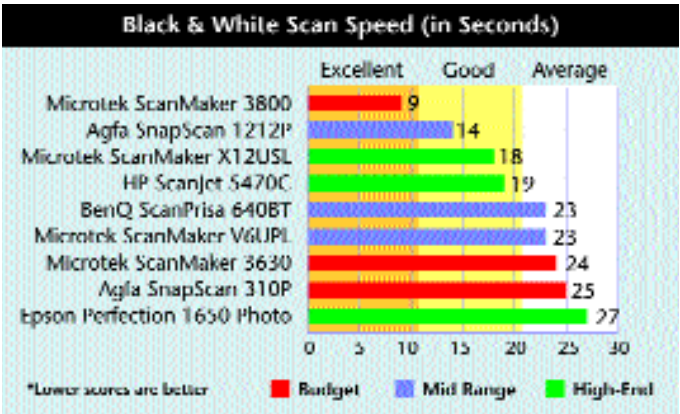
9.25, which was incidentally also the lowest score across all categories.

In the high-end segment, the Epson Perfection 1650 came out the winner with a score of 24.5 points, which is over 4 points higher than its nearest competitor, HP ScanJet 5470. The Perfection 1650 is feature-rich, has a detailed user manual as well as a detailed troubleshooting guide. The only two missing features are support for batch scanning and network scanning. The Umax Astra 4000U scored a decent 19.5, but even though it supported network and batch scanning—features that are not common—it fell short as its TWAIN driver didn't offer too many enhanced imaging features.

Performance

A scanner's performance is judged by the quality of the image and the speed at which it is capable of scanning. Whether you should consider speed or quality when buying a scanner will depend on how you plan to use it. If you need to scan in large volumes, the speed should rate higher, but if you need scans for presentations, professional level imaging or printing, the quality of the image is more critical. In fact, if a scanner gives you great quality, you can consider compromising a little on speed.

Black and white scan speed: On an average, we found that most budget scanners took about 30 seconds to scan a black and white text document. The scanner that really stood out here was the Microtek ScanMaker 3800, finishing the scan in a blazing 9 seconds! No other scanner came even close to breaking the 20-second barrier in the budget range. The closest that came to it were



the Microtek ScanMaker 3630 and the Agfa SnapScan 310P—both finished the scan in just under 25 seconds. The slower ones, except for the Canon series of scanners, took between 25 to 30 seconds, which is quite tolerable. The Canon CanoScan N640P was by far the slowest in the entire comparison test—it took over a minute (65 seconds) to finish scanning the document. We ran the test several times but got the same result each time.

One would expect the scanning speeds to improve as you move up the price ladder, but this was not the case. Also, scanning black and white documents at 300 dpi should hardly tax a scanner, regardless of whether the scanner has a SCSI, USB or parallel interface—there is hardly enough data to put the interface, scanning engine or the TWAIN driver under any pressure. This fact was brought home in the mid range section: Agfa SnapScan 1212P, which uses a parallel interface, finished scanning the document in just under 14 seconds. On the other hand, Microtek ScanMaker

Speed Tests

Comparing scanner speeds is tricky as the speed of scanning depends on the speed of the scan engine and some of it depends on the scanner's interface with the PC.

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